



BEFORE

The Dong Son culture flourished in Southeast Asia during the 1st millennium BCE.



THE DONG SON

Remains of the Dong Son culture that created this drum (1st–2nd century BCE) were discovered near Hanoi in

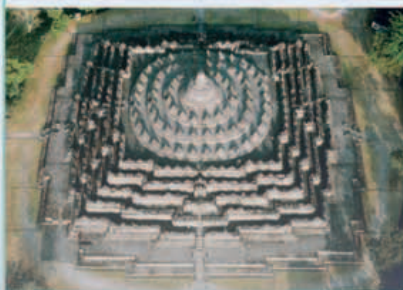
Vietnam in the 1930s. Dong Son culture was centered on

DONG SON DRUM northern Vietnam, but remnants have been found across Southeast Asia as far away as Java and Sumatra. Dongsonians had an organized society that later cultures in the region would draw upon.

HOW WE KNOW

BOROBUDUR TEMPLE

The Buddhist monument of Borobudur in Central Java remained largely hidden by jungle until its rediscovery in 1814. Careful study of carvings and inscriptions around the site suggests that it was constructed under the influence of the Srivijaya Empire in the 8th–9th centuries. Almost 21,500 sq ft (2,000 m²) of narrative sculptures provide information about Buddhist worship and daily life in Java in the period.



Lost Empires

Long seen as a way station for merchants and missionaries, Southeast Asia has also been home to peoples and empires whose commercial, spiritual, and artistic wealth were rivaled by none. This wealth depended on the movement of people, goods, and ideas across the vast waterways and fertile plains of the region.

Among the great numbers of people who migrated along the waterways of Southeast Asia, many moved from the islands of Java and Sumatra to the coasts of today's Vietnam and Cambodia. These people set up maritime trading centers that traded spices, woods, metals, and animal products from inland for merchandise from elsewhere in

Southeast Asia, India, Persia, and Arabia. Many areas grew wealthy as a result of this trade, and the Champa kingdom in southern Vietnam became a great empire, its power and influence lasting from the 7th century CE until its defeat by the Vietnamese emperor 1471.

Rivers and floodplains

The fertile rivers of the Southeast Asian interior were another source of wealth. Communities around the river basins of the Mekong, Red, Chao Phraya, and Irrawaddy rivers grew prosperous from rice and livestock. But the rivers were also a source of conflict as the region's empires fought each other for control the most productive arable areas. As early as the 7th century CE, the rulers of the Khmer people, in modern Cambodia,

had fought the declining Funan empire and the Champa city-states for control of the fertile Mekong River delta. While the power of Funan passed, the Champa and Khmer continued to quarrel over the floodplain. After 939, the Champa also had to contend with the northern Vietnamese state of Dai Viet, which was desperate to find territories south of the

crowded Red River valley. The Champa preoccupation with the Dai Viet let the Khmer Empire strengthen its grip on the rice lands of the Mekong.

At the same time, to the west of the Khmer Empire in

Burma (Myanmar), the Irrawaddy River sustained the growth of a powerful kingdom around the city of Pagan. By the mid-12th century, the Pagan and Khmer empires controlled much of mainland Southeast Asia. As the Khmer began to decline in the 13th century, Thai-speaking peoples migrated down the Irrawaddy and Chao Phraya rivers from farther north and took control of many former



Borobudur relief

The Buddhist monument at Borobudur features 2,672 carved reliefs showing both the Buddhist afterlife and the daily existence of the Javanese people.

Khmer lands. In 1238, they established the first Thai nation, the kingdom of Sukhothai, in central Thailand.

Island kingdoms

The peoples that remained on Sumatra and Java set up prosperous trading communities rivaling the coastal states of the mainland. By the 8th century, the Srivijaya Empire controlled most of Sumatra

